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Testudo hermanni

Hermann's tortoise

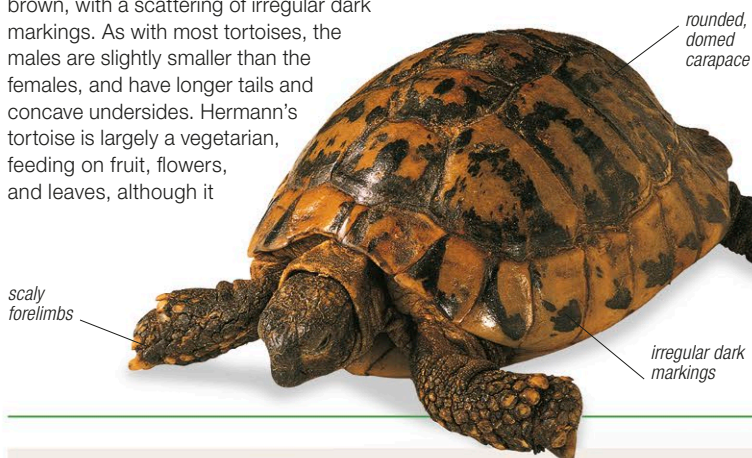


Length 6–8 in (15–20 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Near threatened

Location S.E. Europe, Mediterranean islands

Easily confused with the spur-thighed tortoise (see right), this tortoise is the smallest of 3 species that live in southern Europe. It has a domed and slightly lumpy carapace, colored yellow, olive, or brown, with a scattering of irregular dark markings. As with most tortoises, the males are slightly smaller than the females, and have longer tails and concave undersides. Hermann's tortoise is largely a vegetarian, feeding on fruit, flowers, and leaves, although it

also eats slugs, snails, and animal remains. It lives in places with dense plant cover, forcing its way through the vegetation on its short but powerful legs. It is not active during the hottest part of the day in summer, and in the extreme south, it becomes dormant. Where winters are cold, it also hibernates for several months each year. As with most tortoises, this species hisses and grunts, particularly during the breeding season. Having mated, females dig flask-shaped nesting chambers, where they lay up to 12 eggs. Like the spur-thighed tortoise, this species was once collected in large numbers for the pet trade, but is now fully protected.



Testudo graeca

Spur-thighed tortoise



Length 8–10 in (20–25 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Vulnerable

Location S. Europe, S.W. and W. Asia, N.W. Africa, Mediterranean islands



Conspicuous spurs on the hindlegs give this tortoise its name, and help distinguish it from Hermann's tortoise (see left), which overlaps its range. Its shell is similar to the Hermann's but smoother. It lives in grassy places and sand dunes, and feeds on leaves, fruit, and occasionally carrion and mammal dung. The females lay clutches of up to 12 eggs.

Chersina angulata

Angulate tortoise



Length 6–8 in (15–20 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Not evaluated

Location Southern Africa

Also known as the bowsprit tortoise, this species has a high, domed carapace. It eats grasses and succulents—hibernating during the winter—and, in spite of its armor, provides food for monitor lizards, carnivorous mammals, and even birds of prey. Unusually, the males are slightly larger than the females, and fight with rivals at the onset of the breeding season. Females lay one, or rarely, 2 eggs.



Tuataras

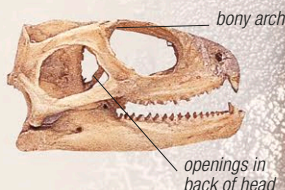
PHYLUM	Chordata
CLASS	Reptilia
ORDER	Rhynchocephalia
FAMILIES	1 (Sphenodontidae)
SPECIES	1

The tuatara is the only representative of a group of reptiles that flourished over 200 million years ago. Found on 2 groups of small islands off the coast of New Zealand, they look similar to lizards. Tuataras live in burrows and are largely nocturnal. Compared to other reptiles, they are remarkably tolerant of cold, remaining active in temperatures as

low as 50° F (10° C). They grow slowly, breed infrequently, and live to a great age (possibly over 100 years).

Anatomy

Tuataras have a large head, a long tail, and well-developed limbs. They have a different skull structure than lizards (see below), and unlike lizards they have no eardrums, middle ear, or external male sexual organ. A "third eye" is situated on the top of the head, but there is no evidence that this is functional.



SKULL SHAPE

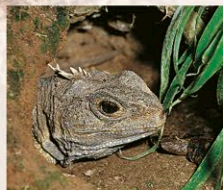
There are 2 openings towards the back of the tuatara's skull; most lizards have only one such opening. The teeth are not separate structures but serrations along the edges of both the upper and lower jaws.

Feeding

Tuataras are almost entirely insectivorous and feed on the large numbers of scavenging beetles and crickets that are attracted to colonies of seabirds. They also eat other invertebrates, small lizards, and, occasionally, the eggs and chicks of birds whose nest holes they share.

BASKING

Although usually nocturnal, tuataras may occasionally be seen basking on rocks on sunny days. Due to a low metabolic rate, they draw breath infrequently, and when at rest may take only one breath an hour.



BURROWING

Tuataras either dig their own burrows or inhabit the nest holes excavated by breeding seabirds, such as small petrels. They usually hunt for food just outside the entrance of the burrow.

Sphenodon punctatus

Tuatara



Length 20–23½ in (50–60 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Burrowing
Status Least concern

Location New Zealand (coastal islands)

With its spiny crest and loose, scaly skin, the tuatara looks deceptively similar to some iguanas (see pp.414–6). It was once widespread in New Zealand, but now survives almost entirely on small, offshore islands, where it is protected from introduced mammals. Adult tuataras feed after dark, with spiders, insects, and worms making up the bulk of their diet. They grow very slowly, and females do not breed until they are at least 20 years old. The eggs spend a year developing inside the female's body, and after being laid, they take at least a year to hatch. Recent genetic analysis indicated that there were two distinct species of tuataras: *S. punctatus* and *S. guntheri*. They are now, however, considered to be insufficiently different to justify full species status, and so *S. guntheri* has been reclassified as a subspecies of *S. punctatus*.

